

Shorter and Simpler: Customizing Generative AI Responses Can Increase Satisfaction, Credibility, and Fact-Checking Intentions

Hui Min Lee

Media Effects Research Laboratory
The Pennsylvania State University
University Park, Pennsylvania, USA
hvl5699@psu.edu

Rehab Alayoubi

Media Effects Research Laboratory
The Pennsylvania State University
University Park, Pennsylvania, USA
rma5877@psu.edu

Peixin Hua

Media Effects Research Laboratory
The Pennsylvania State University
University Park, Pennsylvania, USA
pzh5305@psu.edu

S. Shyam Sundar

Media Effects Research Laboratory
The Pennsylvania State University
University Park, Pennsylvania, USA
Department of Immersive Media Engineering
Sungkyunkwan University
Seoul, Republic of Korea
sss12@psu.edu

Abstract

As generative AI becomes increasingly popular, some platforms have started to offer customization options, allowing users to modify responses to become shorter or longer. This study explores the impact of these customization options on user experience and perceived credibility of the generative AI tool. In an experiment with three conditions (no/voluntary/forced customization), participants ($N = 194$) interacted with Google Gemini on four health topics. The results showed that customization increased perceived control, which was positively associated with satisfaction with generated responses and source credibility. Perceived control brought about by customizing also had an empowering effect by boosting fact-checking intentions. Our findings offer novel design insights for customization affordances in generative AI platforms, and we provide recommendations on ways to leverage customization to jointly improve both user experience and socially responsible use of AI.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

Keywords

Customization, Satisfaction, Credibility, Fact-checking Intentions

ACM Reference Format:

Hui Min Lee, Peixin Hua, Rehab Alayoubi, and S. Shyam Sundar. 2025. Shorter and Simpler: Customizing Generative AI Responses Can Increase Satisfaction, Credibility, and Fact-Checking Intentions. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '25)*, April 26–May 01, 2025, Yokohama, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 7 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3719749>

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).
CHI EA '25, Yokohama, Japan

© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).
ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1395-8/25/04
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3719749>

1 Introduction

Many generative AI platforms offer users the ability to customize the AI's output. For instance, Microsoft Copilot allows users to select from various conversation styles, such as "More creative," "More balanced," or "More precise," while Google Gemini provides users with five granular response modification options: shorter, longer, simpler, more casual, or more professional.¹ While users are free to engage in continuous interaction with the generative AI tool and prompt the chatbot towards desired responses, they may also benefit from such pre-determined customization options. These options signal the potential functionalities of these new platforms, serving as cues that enhance user experience. In fact, research on websites and games show that customization often leads to positive attitudinal outcomes [3, 15]. It can enhance the perceived credibility of an interface and its content by triggering certain cognitive heuristics, such as the belief that having more control is better [10], which can sometimes have adverse effects on responsible use of generative AI by promoting overtrust of its content. Through an experimental study investigating how users interact with Google Gemini, this study examines how customization features affect user satisfaction, perceived message and source credibility, and fact-checking intentions. Understanding these relationships has important practical implications for AI developers, organizations, and users: it can inform the design of AI interfaces to encourage both user satisfaction and responsible AI use, help organizations develop better guidelines for implementing generative AI tools, and even empower users to make more informed decisions about when to verify AI-generated information.

¹When this study was conducted in April 2024, this was the format of the Google Gemini customization options. On the date of writing this manuscript, it appears that this Google Gemini customization function appears in a different format, with only three options (to regenerate, make shorter, or make longer) when users highlight a specific portion of the generated response.

2 Related Work

2.1 Customization of Generative AI Responses

Customization affordances—the ability to modify responses to be shorter, longer, or more professional—are a prominent feature in new generative AI tools. Prior research has shown that customization has positive psychological effects. For example, one study found that customizing an avatar reduced psychological reactance toward persuasive messages by the avatar, leading to increased willingness to accept the message and ultimately, greater liking towards the content [8]. Another study found that chatbots that personalized interactions according to the user's preferences also induced a sense of respect and value for the user, increasing user satisfaction [16]. From a design perspective, the ability to customize is a signal to users that the chatbot is genuinely interested in helping the user, causing them to view the chatbot as reliable and trusted [16]. Additionally, customization can lead to chatbot responses being tailored to one's language skills and educational level, enhancing user experience [2]. Given these positive effects of customization, we first propose:

H1: Customizing generative AI responses (vs no customization) will enhance user satisfaction.

2.2 Agency Model of Customization

Theoretically, the effects of customization in generative AI may be understood through the agency model of customization [25] and its adaptation for the theory of interactive media effects or TIME [27]. The model specifically discusses the psychological implications of making choices, proposing that customization is key in allowing users to assert their agency and creating a sense of self-as-source. The notion of customization lies in centering the individual user in the interactive experience, meaning that every user's experience is unique [13]. Sundar and Marathe [28] further elaborate on how customization is user-initiated, featuring affordances that allow users to make changes to the interface, rather than having individualized content delivered to the user without user action or choice. The user is therefore put in the driver's seat, becoming the source of the interaction, or positioning them as an active participant rather than a passive consumer of AI's responses [25]. Given this, what, then, are the implications of allowing users to make seemingly superficial changes, such as modifying the generated response to be shorter, more casual, or more professional?

The agency model [25] proposes that customization leads to a perception of control, which is the feeling of being in charge of the interaction and the perception that one can make different choices in the interactive medium [18]. This occurs in a variety of contexts, such as when customizing one's avatar in an online virtual environment [30] or customizing the design of an online website [14]. Theoretically, customization is also related to the notion of an extended self [4], referring to how our possessions are reflections of our identities. By controlling an object for our purposes, the object becomes incorporated into a notion of ourselves. Applied to new media technologies such as generative AI, customization increases user control and allows users to better appreciate the interactive platform [32]. Thus, we propose:

H2: Customizing generative AI responses (vs no customization) will increase perceived control, which is positively associated with user satisfaction.

However, experiencing an extension of the self via the perception of control can also have complex implications for how individuals form credibility judgments when considering generative AI. There is evidence to suggest that the act of customization may increase trust in generative AI. For example, Wald et al. [31] found that customizing a chatbot along humanistic traits increased trust, an effect mediated by anthropomorphism. Similarly, Xiao et al. [33] found that customizing an embodied conversational agent to speak slower or faster, or more casually or more formally, caused participants to rate the agent as more trustworthy. This effect extends to other platforms—previous research has shown that experiencing greater control on mobile apps can increase the credibility of the app itself [12], while another study found that experiencing higher levels of control predicted perceived credibility of the interactive news story [10]. However, while high source credibility is typically a desired outcome, extremely high levels of source credibility (or trust) may be concerning in the context of generative AI. For example, perceiving that ChatGPT is a credible information source may lead one to be less likely to verify its generated output against trustworthy sources.

This is especially concerning, given that the growing use of generative AI across various domains has increased the possibility of overtrust in its responses. Research has found that compared to the Google search engine, people showed more trust in ChatGPT when they were seeking health information [24], a tendency that has led to real-world consequences, from medical misinformation to the notable 2023 legal incident, where two lawyers and a law firm were fined for submitting fictitious case law information generated by ChatGPT as part of their legal research [1]. Some scholars thus note that the use of generative AI necessitates individual literacy to determine the veracity of information generated [20]. As is the case with other types of online information, it will be important to carefully process the generated content and even fact-check the information.

However, under conditions of high source credibility, individuals may readily accept AI-generated responses, seeing no need to look for clues to assess information credibility [17]. These may have further implications for how users engage with generative AI, such as their likelihood of fact-checking generated responses. Thus, while customization may enhance user engagement and satisfaction, it can potentially affect users' motivation to critically evaluate AI-generated content via enhanced credibility perceptions as well. Hence, we propose:

H3: Customizing generative AI responses (vs no customization) will increase perceived control, which is associated with (a) higher source credibility, and subsequently (b) lower fact-checking intentions.

3 Method

We conducted a between-subjects experiment examining how customization features in Google Gemini's interface affect user behavior and perceptions. Gemini was selected as our experimental platform due to its robust customization features, including built-in

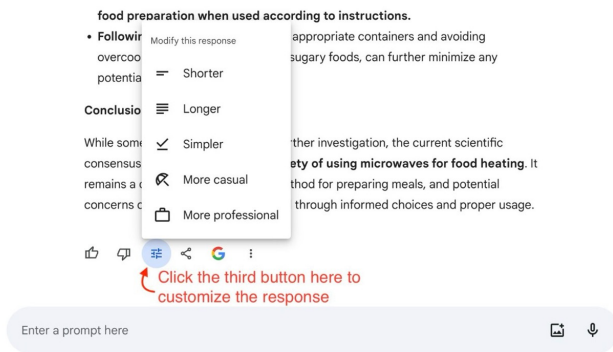


Figure 1: Google Gemini Customization Options and Instructions

response modification options (Figure 1). The study employed three conditions: no customization (control), forced customization, and voluntary customization.

3.1 Participants, Stimuli, and Procedure

Participants ($N = 194$) were recruited from communications classes at a major university in the United States through the department's research participation system. Consent was obtained, and students were offered extra credits to participate in the study. 45 participants were excluded from the analysis because they did not consent or failed either the attention or the manipulation checks. The final sample consisted of 149 valid responses, aged between 18 to 32 years ($M = 19.92$, $SD = 1.57$), 65.1% of which identified as females. All participants were undergraduate students, with 79.2% identifying as White/Caucasian.

To examine how users evaluate AI-generated information across different contexts, all participants interacted with Gemini using four assigned prompts, each containing a different contentious health topic that individuals may question in their everyday lives. The four prompts were presented in a random order to prevent order effects, including: (a) "Is unpasteurized milk better for you?" (b) "Is sunscreen bad for my health?" (c) "Does cracking joints cause arthritis?" and (d) "Will sleeping with wet hair cause a cold?". Although Gemini provides a unique response to every user, the content of the response for each prompt is extremely similar. Participants were also instructed to copy and paste the generated response into the questionnaire, which allowed us to confirm that there was high consistency in the responses received by all participants.

All participants were told that the purpose of the study was to understand users' interactions with generative AI. After assessing them on control variables, we randomly assigned them to one of three conditions: no customization, forced customization, or voluntary customization. The reason for including a voluntary condition is ecological validity, as it better reflects how users naturally interact with generative AI in real-world settings. Previous research has suggested that forced actions may lead to effects that are different from those of voluntary action [23], particularly in media environments where user autonomy and choice are paramount. Including this condition thus allows us to capture any naturalistic

decision-making processes that occur when users have agency over whether to customize content, which more accurately represents typical human-AI interactions.

Next, participants were directed to the Google Gemini page, which they accessed with their personal Google accounts, and then entered the first prompt presented to them. They were given instructions to copy and paste the generated response in the questionnaire for verification. Those in the voluntary and forced customization conditions were then brought to a separate page, where we provided them with the respective customization options, and instructed them to copy and paste their latest customized response back in the Qualtrics page. Conversely, those in the no customization condition were not shown this page and simply brought to the next prompt. This process was repeated four times for each prompt. Finally, participants answered questions regarding the dependent variables and their demographic information. The entire procedure took approximately 15 to 20 minutes.

3.2 Customization Manipulation

To manipulate customization, participants were provided different instructions. Those in the forced customization condition ($N = 56$) were given explicit instructions to "please customize by asking Gemini to modify its response," while participants in the voluntary customization condition ($N = 51$) were told to "please feel free to explore the following customization options," meaning that they could choose whether to customize or not. Those in the no customization condition ($N = 42$) did not receive any instruction to customize. While they were still able to see the option to customize at the bottom of their answer, we did not direct their attention towards this affordance. As a manipulation check, participants were asked whether they modified Gemini's response at least once.

3.3 Measures

Perceived control (1 = *strongly disagree*; 7 = *strongly agree*) was measured by three items such as "I felt I had a say in the content-generation process." [11] ($M = 3.92$, $SD = 1.35$, cronbach's alpha = .84).

Source credibility was measured by asking participants to rate their responses on a 7-point semantic-differential scale following the statement "Gemini AI is ____." Response options included items such as "Informed - uninformed." [19] ($M = 4.93$, $SD = 0.75$, cronbach's alpha = .79).

Satisfaction with Gemini's response was measured by four items adapted from Fu et al. and Bhattacharjee [5, 6]. Participants were asked "How do you feel about your overall experience of retrieving information from Gemini?" and rated their responses on a 7-point semantic-differential scale. The questions included items such as "very dissatisfied - very satisfied." ($M = 5.43$, $SD = 1.01$, cronbach's alpha = .92).

Fact-checking intention was measured by five items adapted from Ștefăniță et al. [22] (1 = *strongly disagree*; 7 = *strongly agree*). Questions included "I intend to verify Gemini's responses with what other people say online." ($M = 4.32$, $SD = 1.44$, cronbach's alpha = .88).

We also measured other variables such as AI attitudes, and machine heuristic as statistical controls, however a randomization

check showed no differences in these variables between conditions, hence they were excluded from subsequent analysis.

3.4 Analysis Plan

Randomization checks showed that there was a significant difference in participants' familiarity with Gemini, $F(2, 146) = 3.94, p = .02$. Therefore, familiarity with Gemini was included as a covariate in our analyses, and the effect of customization on user satisfaction (H1) was analyzed using an ANCOVA. This allowed us to account for differences in familiarity with Gemini. All proposed mediation effects (H2, H3) were analyzed using the PROCESS macro, using 5,000 samples for 95% CI [9].

In our analysis, we also only compared the forced condition against the no customization condition. This was to allow causal inferences about the effects of customization, since the act of customizing was randomly assigned and not self-selected by participants. Including the voluntary condition would have introduced self-selection bias, as participants who chose to customize might differ systematically from those who did not, on unmeasured variables (e.g., technological proficiency, curiosity, or openness), making it impossible to isolate the effects of customization itself. Furthermore, in the voluntary condition, only two participants did not choose to customize—this is something we further address in the discussion section. As a final check, we also ran all analyses by including the voluntary condition and the results follow the same pattern, thus the voluntary condition was ultimately excluded to maintain the internal validity of the study. Zero-order Pearson's correlations show how key continuous variables are related to each other (Appendix Table A1).

4 Results

4.1 H1: Impact of Customization on User Satisfaction

H1 predicted that customization would lead to higher satisfaction. Results showed that participants in the no customization condition ($M = 5.27, SD = .92$) had lower satisfaction towards Gemini's responses than those in the forced condition ($M = 5.54, SD = 1.07$), but the difference was not statistically significant, $F(1, 95) = 1.63, p = .21$. H1 was not supported.

4.2 H2: Role of Perceived Control

H2 predicted that customization will increase perceived control, which is positively associated with satisfaction. Before conducting the mediation analysis for H2, we first confirmed the significant effect of customization on perceived control through an ANCOVA, which showed that participants in the no customization condition ($M = 3.57, SD = 1.35$) had lower perceived control over Gemini's responses than those in the forced condition ($M = 4.17, SD = 1.31$), $F(1, 95) = 5.13, p = .026$. Next, results from PROCESS model 4 showed that customization led to higher perceived control ($b = .31, SE = .14, p = .03$), which was positively associated with satisfaction ($b = .37, SE = .07, p < .001$). The indirect effect was significant, $b = .11, SE = .06, 95\% CI = [.01, .25]$. H2 was supported.

4.3 H3: Source Credibility and Fact-Checking Intentions

H3 predicted that customization will increase perceived control, which predicts higher source credibility and subsequently lower fact-checking intentions. Results from PROCESS model 6 showed that customization led to higher perceived control ($b = .31, SE = .14, p = .03$), which was positively associated with source credibility ($b = .23, SE = .05, p = .00$). However, source credibility was not significantly associated with fact-checking intentions ($b = -.03, SE = .21, p = .87$). There was no significant mediating effect, $b = .00, SE = .01, 95\% CI = [-.03, .03]$. H3 was not supported.

4.4 User Customization Preference

We were also able to ask about the specific customization options that participants had selected across all four health-related prompts (Appendix Table A2). The option to customize the response to be "simpler" (87 participants) or "shorter" (84 participants) emerged as the most popular customization options.

4.5 Exploratory Analysis

Although we did not find any hypothesized effects on fact-checking intentions, we were also interested to understand the direct relationship between perceived control and fact-checking intentions. A mediation analysis conducted using PROCESS model 4 showed that customization increased perceived control ($b = .31, SE = .14, p = .03$), which was positively associated with fact-checking intentions ($b = .25, SE = .11, p = .03$). There was a significant indirect effect, $b = .08, SE = .05, 95\% CI = [.00, .19]$.

Given the strong total effect between the variables, we also tested the indirect relationship between customization, perceived control, and source credibility using PROCESS model 4. Results showed that perceived control was positively associated with source credibility ($b = .23, SE = .05, p < .001$), and there was a significant indirect effect, $b = .07, SE = .04, 95\% CI = [.01, .15]$. All mediation models are presented in Appendix Figures A1-A4.

4.6 Findings From Open-Ended Questions

As part of our study, we asked participants to list up to five thoughts they had after their interaction with Gemini AI. Our analysis of these open-ended responses revealed several key patterns that complement our quantitative findings. For example, while some participants provided brief, superficial comments such as "Helpful and informative," or "Responses were well organized," others offered more in-depth, thoughtful insights about their interaction experience with Google Gemini. A particularly notable theme emerged regarding platform trust and brand association. For instance, one participant noted that "I felt better about using Gemini AI rather than other generative AI tools like ChatGPT because Google feels like a more familiar company." This sentiment suggests that existing brand relationships and familiarity may play a significant role in shaping users' initial credibility perceptions of AI interfaces, extending beyond the immediate interaction experience we measured quantitatively.

Participants' responses regarding customization affordances also revealed some interesting contradictions that were not captured in our quantitative analysis. While some participants embrace the

flexibility provided by customization options (e.g., “*I felt the ability to modify my response was an interesting feature and created more flexibility in the generation process.*”) others expressed reservations (e.g., “*I didn’t agree with tampering with the AI settings.*”). This qualitative data complements our statistical findings by showcasing the complex ways in which users think about and interact with AI systems, suggesting that future research may benefit from more nuanced methods of analyzing these multifaceted user experiences.

5 Discussion

This study sought to explain the effects of customization on user satisfaction and fact-checking intentions. Using an experimental study, we found that customization affordances in generative AI platforms operate primarily through the psychological mechanism of perceived control. Most notably, increased perceived control was associated with both higher credibility perceptions and increased fact-checking intentions, suggesting that individuals are able to simultaneously trust an AI system while maintaining critical evaluation of its generated output. This is a significant breakthrough for how to design interfaces that balance user engagement and responsible AI use.

The study also found that customization of generative AI responses did not produce a significant total effect on satisfaction, which contradicts findings from other studies noting the positive attitudinal effects of customization [16]. However, it is important to note that perceived control mediated the relationship between customization and satisfaction, suggesting that the psychological mechanisms that underlie the effects of customization are crucial. As other studies on interactivity and customization have suggested, the perception of control is perhaps more important in achieving positive outcomes than the actual affordance provided [34]. This supports the agency model of customization [25], which discusses how customization may lead to a feeling of being in charge of the interaction [18]. Hence, the value of customization features lies not in their mere presence on the interface, but in how they can shape users’ sense of agency and control. This insight has direct implications for interface design: rather than focusing solely on providing multiple customization options, designers could prioritize features that enhance users’ sense of agency and control during the interaction.

Notably, the finding that customization both increased perceived control and fact-checking intentions also supports the notion that fact-checking intentions may not be directly related to credibility perceptions. Rather, it is possible that the perception of control created a feeling of empowerment that motivated users to fact-check [29], even when they perceived Gemini to be credible. Indeed, a previous study found that engaging in an online co-creation task increased perceived empowerment and enjoyment [7]. This distinction has important implications for interface design, suggesting the need for different design strategies to manage platform trust versus content trust.

This may also suggest that the relationship between credibility and fact-checking intentions are more complex than we had initially hypothesized. First, the need for fact-checking arises when messages presented are perceived as questionable or even deceitful

[21]. However, the prompts we provided, such as whether sunscreen is bad for health or if cracking joints cause arthritis, may not be viewed as contentious by our participants. The relationship between credibility and fact-checking may also be complicated by users’ general AI literacy—those who better understand AI’s capabilities and limitations may be more inclined to verify AI’s generated responses. This also aligns with research on perceived control in technology adoption, which suggests that users who feel more in control of their interaction with technology are more likely to engage critically with it rather than passively accept its output. That said, to the extent that individuals experienced perceived control, they were also more likely to also experience high source credibility, affirming the effects of the cue and action routes in the Human-AI Interaction model based on the Theory of Interactive Media Effects (HAI-TIME) [26].

Overall, we found support for the proposition that customizing generative AI responses can be a promising strategy to encourage users to critically evaluate AI-generated information, especially through its positive associations with fact-checking intentions. It is important to note that customization of Gemini’s responses in this study were mainly cosmetic in nature [18]—modifying a response to be shorter, longer, or more casual only changed the style of the information presented, but not the actual content. Customization’s ability to influence perceptions of the source is hence an illuminating insight into the power of customization on message-related outcomes, supporting prior studies that found positive effects of customization on outcomes such as message persuasion [8]. In fact, as our descriptive analyses showed, most participants selected the shorter or simpler customization option, yet these more succinct responses had the ability to improve the credibility of Gemini, further supporting the idea that it was the act of customizing, not the generated responses, that led to enhanced credibility perceptions. This finding suggests that designers should prioritize customization options that reduce cognitive load while maintaining user engagement.

5.1 Theoretical and Design Implications

Our findings have several implications. We extend literature on the HAI-TIME model [26], as well as the agency model of customization [25], showing that perceived control can simultaneously enhance trust and critical evaluation of AI’s responses. While on the one hand perceived control engenders greater trust in the system, it also seems to encourage greater scrutiny of the content. This opens up different theoretical mechanisms for explaining the effects of customization on trust via engagement—on the one hand, it focuses user attention to content but on the other hand, it signals an appreciation of the benevolence of the system (in allowing users to tailor content). This also opens up two different loci of trust in Human-AI interaction—trust in content, as distinct from trust in the system or platform.

These findings also offer several recommendations for AI interface designers who are seeking to balance user engagement with responsible AI use. First, designers should prioritize features that explicitly signal and reinforce the user’s sense of control throughout the interaction journey. This could be achieved through visual

feedback mechanisms that acknowledge users' modifications, or progress indicators that show how user inputs shape AI outputs.

Customization affordances can also be viewed as a strategic friction point to create thoughtful breaks that encourage users' reflection of content while maintaining the interaction flow. For example, offering preview modes of different customization options before finalizing AI-generated content, or including brief prompts that encourage users to consider whether the current output meets their needs, can be ways to empower users to engage in more critical evaluation of generated responses.

5.2 Limitations and Future Directions

While our study provides several valuable insights, some limitations should be noted. First, the small sample size, along with the use of an existing platform, Google Gemini, where we had low control over users' actual interactions, are key limitations of this study. Next, although we tested four different types of prompts, we only made use of one existing platform, and future research should therefore replicate this study with other generative AI tools. That said, our results show that despite users having different views towards customization affordances, simple cosmetic changes in the form of such affordances have the potential to increase users' perceived control, credibility perceptions of the platform and response generated, as well as fact-checking intentions. Given the value of this affordance, developers and platform designers may consider ways to make such customization affordances more visible to users. We urge future studies to extend this research to other generative AI platforms and explore the effects of other forms of customization.

Acknowledgments

This research was supported in part by the MSIT (Ministry of Science, ICT), Republic of Korea, under the Global Scholars Invitation Program (RS-2024-00459638) administered by IITP (Institute for Information & Communication Technology Planning & Evaluation).

References

- [1] [n.d.]. Lawyers submitted bogus case law created by ChatGPT. A judge fined them \$5,000 — apnews.com. <https://apnews.com/article/artificial-intelligence-chatgpt-fake-case-lawyers-d6ae9fa79d0542db9e1455397aef381c>. [Accessed 05-03-2025].
- [2] Abdullah M Baabdullah, Ali Abdullah Alalwan, Raed S Algharabat, Bhimaraya Metri, and Nripendra P Rana. 2022. Virtual agents and flow experience: An empirical examination of AI-powered chatbots. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* 181 (2022), 121772.
- [3] Jean Beier. 2007. *The effects of customization and recommendation source on reader perceptions of a news website*. Master's thesis. The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
- [4] Russell W Belk. 1988. Possessions and the extended self. *Journal of consumer research* 15, 2 (1988), 139–168.
- [5] Anol Bhattacharjee. 2001. Understanding information systems continuance: An expectation-confirmation model. *MIS quarterly* (2001), 351–370.
- [6] Chung-Jen Fu, Andri Dayarana K Silalahi, I-Tung Shih, IJ Eunike, and S Jargal-saikhan. 2024. Balancing Satisfaction and Clarity: Enhancing User Information Satisfaction with AI-Powered ChatGPT in Higher Education.
- [7] Johann Füller, Hans Mühlbacher, Kurt Matzler, and Gregor Jaweck. 2009. Consumer empowerment through internet-based co-creation. *Journal of management information systems* 26, 3 (2009), 71–102.
- [8] Michael D Hanus and Jesse Fox. 2017. Source customization reduces psychological reactance to a persuasive message via user control and identity perceptions. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 17, 1 (2017), 1–12.
- [9] Andrew F Hayes. 2017. *Introduction to mediation, moderation, and conditional process analysis: A regression-based approach*. Guilford publications.
- [10] Michael A Horning. 2017. Interacting with news: Exploring the effects of modality and perceived responsiveness and control on news source credibility and enjoyment among second screen viewers. *Computers in human behavior* 73 (2017), 273–283.
- [11] Yan Huang and S Shyam Sundar. 2022. Do we trust the crowd? Effects of crowd-sourcing on perceived credibility of online health information. *Health Communication* 37, 1 (2022), 93–102.
- [12] Eunsin Joo. 2018. *Sponsor Visibility, Customization, and User Control in the Era of Interactive Technology: Effects on Causal Attribution of Sponsor's Motives, Sponsor Attitudes, and Credibility in the Context of Sponsored Mobile Health-Related Apps*. Michigan State University.
- [13] Sriram Kalyanaram and S Shyam Sundar. 2006. The psychological appeal of personalized content in web portals: Does customization affect attitudes and behavior? *Journal of Communication* 56, 1 (2006), 110–132.
- [14] Hyunjin Kang and S Shyam Sundar. 2016. When self is the source: Effects of media customization on message processing. *Media Psychology* 19, 4 (2016), 561–588.
- [15] Keunyeong Kim, Michael G Schmierbach, Mun-Young Chung, Julia Daisy Fraustino, Frank Dardis, Lee Ahern, et al. 2015. Is it a sense of autonomy, control, or attachment? Exploring the effects of in-game customization on game enjoyment. *Computers in Human Behavior* 48 (2015), 695–705.
- [16] Fong Yee Lee and Tak Jie Chan. 2024. Establishing credibility in AI chatbots: the importance of customization, communication competency and user satisfaction. In *4th International Conference on Communication, Language, Education and Social Sciences (CLESS 2023)*. Atlantis Press, 88–106.
- [17] Teun Lucassen and Jan Maarten Schraagen. 2012. Propensity to trust and the influence of source and medium cues in credibility evaluation. *Journal of information science* 38, 6 (2012), 566–577.
- [18] Sampada Marathe and S Shyam Sundar. 2011. What drives customization? Control or identity?. In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI conference on human factors in computing systems*. 781–790.
- [19] James C McCroskey and Jason J Teven. 1999. Goodwill: A reexamination of the construct and its measurement. *Communications Monographs* 66, 1 (1999), 90–103.
- [20] Scott Monteith, Tasha Glenn, John R Geddes, Peter C Whybrow, Eric Achtyes, and Michael Bauer. 2024. Artificial intelligence and increasing misinformation. *The British Journal of Psychiatry* 224, 2 (2024), 33–35.
- [21] Gordon Pennycook, Ziv Epstein, Mohsen Mosleh, Antonio A Arechar, Dean Eckles, and David G Rand. 2021. Shifting attention to accuracy can reduce misinformation online. *Nature* 592, 7855 (2021), 590–595.
- [22] Oana Ștefăniță, Nicoleta Corbu, and Raluca Buturoiu. 2018. Fake news and the third-person effect: They are more influenced than me and you. *Journal of Media research* 11, 3 (2018).
- [23] Natalie Jomini Stroud, Lauren Feldman, Magdalena Wojcieszak, and Bruce Bimber. 2019. The consequences of forced versus selected political media exposure. *Human Communication Research* 45, 1 (2019), 27–51.
- [24] Xin Sun, Rongjun Ma, Xiaochang Zhao, Zhuying Li, Janne Lindqvist, Abdullah El Ali, and Jos A Bosch. 2024. Trusting the search: unraveling human trust in health information from Google and ChatGPT. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2403.09987* (2024).
- [25] S Shyam Sundar. 2008. Self as source: Agency and customization in interactive media. In *Mediated interpersonal communication*. Routledge, 72–88.
- [26] S Shyam Sundar. 2020. Rise of machine agency: A framework for studying the psychology of human-AI interaction (HAII). *Journal of computer-mediated communication* 25, 1 (2020), 74–88.
- [27] S Shyam Sundar, Haiyan Jia, T Franklin Waddell, and Yan Huang. 2015. Toward a theory of interactive media effects (TIME) four models for explaining how interface features affect user psychology. *The handbook of the psychology of communication technology* (2015), 47–86.
- [28] S Shyam Sundar and Sampada S Marathe. 2010. Personalization versus customization: The importance of agency, privacy, and power usage. *Human communication research* 36, 3 (2010), 298–322.
- [29] S Shyam Sundar, Jeeyun Oh, Saraswathi Bellur, Haiyan Jia, and Hyang-Sook Kim. 2012. Interactivity as self-expression: A field experiment with customization and blogging. In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI conference on human factors in computing systems*. 395–404.
- [30] T Franklin Waddell, S Shyam Sundar, and Joshua Auriemma. 2015. Can customizing an avatar motivate exercise intentions and health behaviors among those with low health ideals? *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking* 18, 11 (2015), 687–690.
- [31] Rebecca Wald, Evelien Heijlselaar, and Tibor Bosse. 2021. Make your own: The potential of chatbot customization for the development of user trust. In *Adjunct proceedings of the 29th ACM conference on user modeling, adaptation and personalization*. 382–387.
- [32] Bartosz W Wojdyski et al. 2015. Affording Control. In *The Handbook of the Psychology of Communication Technology*.
- [33] Jun Xiao, John Stasko, and Richard Catrambone. 2007. The role of choice and customization on users' interaction with embodied conversational agents: effects on perception and performance. In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI conference on Human factors in computing systems*. 1293–1302.

[34] Fan Yang and Fuyuan Shen. 2018. Effects of web interactivity: A meta-analysis. *Communication Research* 45, 5 (2018), 635–658.

6 Appendices

Table A1: Zero-Order Correlations between All Key Variables

Variables	1	2	3	4	5
1. Perceived control	—				
2. Source credibility	.37***	—			
3. Satisfaction	.48***	.56***	—		
4. Fact-checking intentions	.21*	.08	.01	—	
5. [Missing variable]					—

Note. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table A2: Breakdown of Customization Options Selected by Users

Customization Option	Percentage of users (%)
Shorter	58.4 ($N = 87$)
Longer	28.9 ($N = 43$)
Simpler	56.4 ($N = 84$)
More casual	40.3 ($N = 60$)
More professional	30.2 ($N = 45$)

Note. $N = 149$. Because participants were able to customize more than once throughout the study, the sum of the percentage figures exceeds 100%.

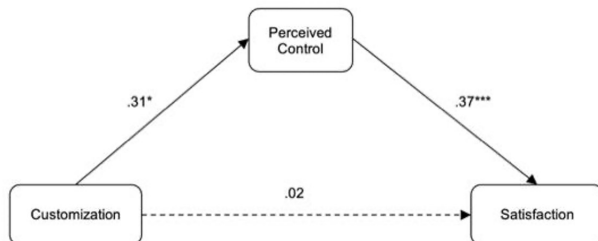


Figure A1: Mediation Effect for H2. All coefficients reported are unstandardized beta coefficients. There was a significant indirect effect, $b = .11$, $SE = .06$, 95% CI = [.01, .25]. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

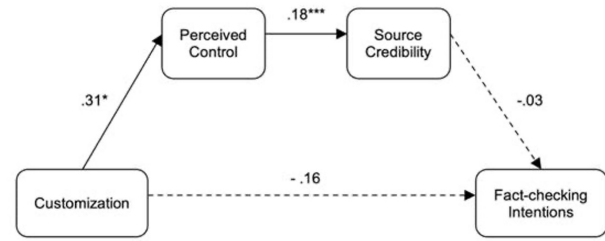


Figure A2: Mediation Effect for H3. All coefficients reported are unstandardized beta coefficients. There was no significant serial indirect effect. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

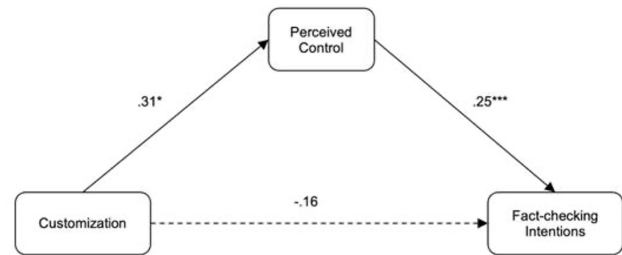


Figure A3: Mediation Effect from Customization to Perceived Control to Fact-checking Intentions. All coefficients reported are unstandardized beta coefficients. There was a significant indirect effect, $b = .08$, $SE = .05$, 95% CI = [.00, .19]. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.

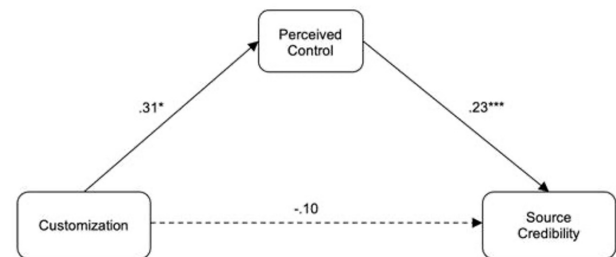


Figure A4: Mediation Effect from Customization to Perceived Control to Source Credibility. All coefficients reported are unstandardized beta coefficients. There was a significant indirect effect, $b = .07$, $SE = .04$, 95% CI = [.01, .15]. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$.